Guitar Exercises - Section XV, Level 101

Larger-Form Composition

A/B Sections • Verse/Chorus Contrast • Bridges • Transitions • Thematic Return • 16-32 Bar Originals

Level 101 of the fixed 105-level core curriculum. HARD STOP after Level 105.

Level 100 proved that a small idea can generate eight coherent bars. Level 101 asks a harder question: how does one idea become a complete form without either repeating too literally or abandoning its identity?

Module	Exercise	Events
A	A/B contrast from shared source material	144
B	Verse/chorus contrast and return	144
C	Bridge construction and harmonic departure	128
D	Transitions, pickups, and connective bars	128
E	Thematic return and variation	128
F	16-bar form construction	144
G	32-bar form construction	160
H	Four complete larger-form composition studies	224
I	Thirty-two-bar original composition capstone	320
J	Revision, reduction, and authorship audit	64
	TOTAL	1584

Core rule: contrast should sound new; return should sound remembered.

Reference - Larger-Form Hierarchy

Layer	Question
A section	What establishes the piece's identity?
B section	What changes while still belonging to the same piece?
Bridge	What departs far enough to create perspective?
Transition	How does one section prepare the next?
Return	What must recur for the listener to recognize home?
Development	What changes on repetition?
Climax	Where is the largest structural event?
Ending	What proves the form is complete?

Write the section jobs before writing all the notes.

Module A - A/B Contrast from Shared Material

Variable	A section	B section
Motif	original contour	inverted or sequenced
Harmony	tonic-centered	relative/neighboring function
Register	middle	higher or lower
Rhythm	stable	more syncopated or more spacious
Density	sparse	denser or intentionally thinner
Dynamics	mp	mf/f or p contrast
Texture	single-note/triad	double-stop/chordal/bass-led

Create four A/B pairs. Change only two variables at first; preserve the rest.

Module A - Identity Preservation Test

Test	Question
Rhythm-only	Can the relationship between A and B still be heard?
Melody-only	Does B sound related without the chords?
Bass-only	Does the harmonic direction still make sense?
Reduction	Can both sections survive at 50% note density?
Return	Does A sound recognizable after B?
Transposition	Does the A/B relationship survive a new key?

If B sounds like a different song, restore one identity-bearing feature from A.

Module B - Verse/Chorus Contrast

Dimension	Verse	Chorus
Harmony	more cyclic / less resolved	stronger arrival
Register	middle/low	higher/wider
Rhythm	more conversational	more declarative/repeated
Melody	narrower range	larger interval or higher target
Dynamics	mp/mf	mf/f
Phrase length	may leave question open	should feel conclusive or memorable

Write two 8-bar verse/chorus pairs. The chorus must feel larger even when performed at the same volume.

Module B - Chorus Hook Construction

Hook type	Constraint
Rhythmic	same 1-bar rhythm repeated over changing chords
Melodic	4-note contour repeated twice
Harmonic	distinct chord loop not used in verse
Register	same motif moved up an octave
Lyric-free instrumental	one memorable guitar phrase at chorus entrance
Bass hook	bass figure repeats while harmony moves above it

A chorus hook should survive a plain-tone performance with no effects or advanced articulation.

Module C - Bridge Construction

Bridge strategy	Exercise
New tonal center	move to relative/parallel/neighboring key
New harmonic rhythm	double or halve chord-change rate
Pedal tone	hold one pitch while harmony departs
Chromatic mediant	use once, then reconnect to form
Rhythmic reset	change groove density without changing tempo
Register reset	move to opposite register
Motif absence	remove main motif, then restore it on return
Motif transformation	use inversion/augmentation only

The bridge should create perspective, not erase the piece's identity.

Module C - Bridge Exit Design

Exit type	Task
Dominant setup	last bridge chord points directly to returning tonic
Common-tone return	hold one note into returning section
Rhythmic pickup	bridge rhythm becomes pickup to chorus
Silence	one full beat/bar rest before return
Register fall	high bridge collapses into lower return
Climactic extension	delay return by one bar, then resolve

Loop only the final bridge bar plus the first return bar until the return feels inevitable.

Module D - Transition Bars and Pickups

Transition	Constraint
Static	hold last chord, change texture only
Bass-led	3-4 note bass approach into next root
Melodic	2-4 note pickup into next section target
Harmonic	secondary dominant or passing diminished
Rhythmic	one-bar fill using section's groove vocabulary
Silence	remove material before entrance
Common-tone	sustain one note across change
Metric	same meter, new subdivision emphasis

Write eight one-bar transitions between the same two sections, then rank them by clarity and musical necessity.

Module D - Transition Economy

Version	Allowed content
100%	full transition figure
75%	remove one ornamental event
50%	destination bass + one pickup note
25%	destination chord only
0%	direct cut to next section

A transition is optional unless it improves direction, timing, or identity.

Module E - Thematic Return

Return type	Keep	Change
Exact return	motif/rhythm/harmony	nothing essential
Higher return	motif/rhythm	register
Reharmonized return	melody/rhythm	harmony
Rhythmic return	pitch contour	subdivision
Reduced return	identity notes	density
Expanded return	motif	phrase length
Climactic return	motif	dynamics/register/texture
Fragment return	opening 2-3 notes	rest of phrase

Write one A section and seven different returns. The listener should recognize all seven as descendants of the same material.

Module E - Return Memory Test

Pass	Task
1	play A, wait 8 bars of unrelated vamp, return exactly
2	play A, improvise B, return with higher register
3	play A, bridge with no motif, return reduced
4	play A, transpose bridge, return in original key
5	play A, silence 2 bars, return from memory
6	play only motif fragment to cue return

The return should be retrievable as an idea, not merely as a memorized fretboard sequence.

Module F - Sixteen-Bar Form Construction

Form	Bars	Assignment
A-A'	8+8	second A changes one variable
A-B	8+8	strong contrast without bridge
A-B-A'	6+4+6	compact return form
Verse-Chorus	8+8	distinct hook in chorus
Question-Answer	8+8	second half resolves first
Through-composed	4+4+4+4	new material with one recurring motif

Complete all six forms using the same original 3-4 note motif.

Module G - Thirty-Two-Bar Form Construction

Form	Architecture
AABA	8 + 8 + 8 + 8
ABAB	8 + 8 + 8 + 8
Verse-Chorus-Verse-Chorus	8 + 8 + 8 + 8
A-B-Bridge-A	8 + 8 + 8 + 8
A-A'-B-A"	8 + 8 + 8 + 8
4-section arc	8 establish + 8 build + 8 peak + 8 release

Write a one-sentence job description for each 8-bar block before composing it.

Module G - Section Energy Map

Section	Energy 1-5	Density	Register	Cadence
A	2			
A'/B	3			
Bridge/Peak	4-5			
Return/Release	2-4			

The energy map must be legible even if all articulations are removed.

Module H - Study 1 - A/B instrumental

Write 16 bars: A8 establishes motif; B8 sequences it in new register and altered harmony.

Pass	Requirement
1	section jobs only
2	motif/harmonic skeleton
3	complete first draft
4	transition/return audit
5	arrangement and dynamics
6	record and revise once

Module H - Study 2 - Verse/chorus

Write 16 bars: verse is rhythmically conversational; chorus has one repeated hook and stronger cadence.

Pass	Requirement
1	section jobs only
2	motif/harmonic skeleton
3	complete first draft
4	transition/return audit
5	arrangement and dynamics
6	record and revise once

Module H - Study 3 - A-B-Bridge-A

Write 32 bars. Bridge must omit the main motif until final 2 bars.

Pass	Requirement
1	section jobs only
2	motif/harmonic skeleton
3	complete first draft
4	transition/return audit
5	arrangement and dynamics
6	record and revise once

Module H - Study 4 - 4-section arc

Write 32 bars: establish, develop, peak, release. Only one true climax.

Pass	Requirement
1	section jobs only
2	motif/harmonic skeleton
3	complete first draft
4	transition/return audit
5	arrangement and dynamics
6	record and revise once

Module I - Thirty-Two-Bar Original Composition Capstone

Bars	Section	Job	Requirement	Dynamic
1-8	A	Establish	state motif; tonic-centered	mp
9-16	B	Contrast	new register/harmonic direction	mf
17-24	Bridge	Departure	motif transformed or absent	f peak
25-32	A'	Return	recognizable motif + one meaningful variation	mf -> p

Create one complete 32-bar original. Required deliverables: working title, form map, motif statement, chord/function chart, bass map, melody or lead sheet, transition notes, dynamic arc, performance arrangement, and recorded take.

Module J - Revision, Reduction, and Authorship Audit

Question	Revision task
Does B contrast enough?	change only one additional variable
Does bridge belong?	restore one identity-bearing feature
Does return feel earned?	improve bridge exit or reduce return
Where is the climax?	remove competing peaks
Which transition is unnecessary?	delete it and compare
Which section is too long?	truncate without losing job
Can form survive 50% fewer notes?	perform reduced version
Can you explain every section in one sentence?	rewrite unclear section

Pass Level 101: 14/16 or better across identity, section contrast, bridge function, transition clarity, thematic return, form, revision, and performance. No zero in identity, form, thematic return, or performance.

Next: Level 102 develops arrangement and orchestration for original music: multiple guitar roles, bass/inner-voice design, groove changes, dynamic architecture, solo sections, and demo-ready 32-48 bar arrangements.

Fixed roadmap: Levels 100-104 Composition; Level 105 Final Musicianship Capstone. HARD STOP after Level 105.